

Japan Moving / Address Change Procedures Reference

For foreigners in Japan — verified procedures as of 2026

This file is a knowledge base for an AI-powered Japan Moving Assistant app. Use it to search, filter, and personalize checklist items based on user inputs. Do NOT generate procedures from scratch — use this file as the source of truth.

SCENARIO TYPES

The app supports three main moving scenarios:

- **WITHIN_SAME_MUNICIPALITY** — Moving within the same city/ward/district
- **BETWEEN_MUNICIPALITIES** — Moving to a different city/prefecture within Japan
- **LEAVING_JAPAN** — Moving out of Japan (temporarily or permanently)

Each procedure below is tagged with which scenarios it applies to.

PROCEDURES

1. Moving-Out Notification (転出届 / tenshutsu todoke)

- **Scenarios:** BETWEEN_MUNICIPALITIES, LEAVING_JAPAN

- **Where:** Municipal office (city hall / ward office) of your CURRENT address
 - **Deadline:** Up to 14 days before move, or within 14 days after move
 - **What happens:** You receive a Moving-Out Certificate (転出証明書 / tenshutsu shomeisho). Keep this — you need it for the Moving-In Notification.
 - **Documents needed:**
 - Residence Card (在留カード) for all family members moving - My Number Card or Notification Card (if applicable) - Passport - Personal seal (inkan/hanko) if you have one
 - **Penalty for skipping:** Continued billing for resident tax, NHI, pension. If leaving Japan, may lose eligibility for pension lump-sum withdrawal.
 - **Notes:** For LEAVING_JAPAN, specify your departure date and destination country. This triggers cancellation of NHI and pension enrollment.
-

2. Moving-In Notification (転入届 / tennyu todoke)

- **Scenarios:** BETWEEN_MUNICIPALITIES
 - **Where:** Municipal office of your NEW address
 - **Deadline:** Within 14 days of physically moving in
 - **What happens:** Your Residence Card is updated on the spot (new address printed on the back). This simultaneously satisfies both the Basic Resident Registration Act and Immigration Control Act requirements.
 - **Documents needed:**
 - Residence Card for every family member moving - Moving-Out Certificate (転出証明書) from previous municipality - My Number Card or Notification Card (if applicable) - Proof of family relationship (if applicable, with Japanese translation)
 - **Penalty for missing deadline:** Fine up to 200,000 yen (Immigration Control Act) + up to 50,000 yen (Basic Resident Registration Act). If address is not registered for 90+ days, risk of status of residence revocation.
-

3. Change of Address Notification (転居届 / tenkyo todoke)

- **Scenarios:** WITHIN_SAME_MUNICIPALITY
- **Where:** Your municipal office

- **Deadline:** Within 14 days of moving
 - **What happens:** Address updated in resident registry. Residence Card updated on the spot.
 - **Documents needed:**
 - Residence Card for all family members moving - My Number Card or Notification Card - Health Insurance Cards - Proof of identification
-

4. National Health Insurance (国民健康保険 / NHI) Update

- **Scenarios:** ALL
 - **Where:** Municipal office (usually same visit as address notification)
 - **Deadline:** Same visit as address change notification
 - **Actions by scenario:**
 - WITHIN_SAME_MUNICIPALITY: Address updated automatically with tenkyo todoke
 - BETWEEN_MUNICIPALITIES: Cancel at old municipality, re-enroll at new one
 - LEAVING_JAPAN (permanent): Cancel and return insurance card. Settle outstanding premiums.
 - LEAVING_JAPAN (temporary with re-entry permit): Cancel. You can re-enroll when you return.
 - **Notes:** If covered through employer's social insurance (shakai hoken), employer handles this. Only applies to those on National Health Insurance.
-

5. National Pension (国民年金) Handling

- **Scenarios:** ALL
- **Where:** Municipal office pension window
- **Actions by scenario:**
 - WITHIN_SAME_MUNICIPALITY: No action needed (auto-updated)
 - BETWEEN_MUNICIPALITIES: Re-register at new municipality
 - LEAVING_JAPAN (permanent, not returning): Can claim lump-sum withdrawal (脱退一時金) after departure. Must file within 2 years of leaving. Requires 6+ months of contributions. Max payout = 60 months' contributions. Subject to 20% withholding tax (recoverable via tax representative).
 - LEAVING_JAPAN (temporary, planning to return): You can either (a) keep paying voluntarily from abroad to maintain your pension record, or

(b) stop paying and claim lump-sum withdrawal. If you have Permanent Residency and plan to return, keeping your pension record may be more valuable long-term.

- **Documents for lump-sum withdrawal (filed from abroad):**

- Punched Residence Card (returned at airport) - Passport copy (photo page + visa page + departure stamps) - Foreign bank account details - Application form from Japan Pension Service

6. Residence Card (在留カード) Handling

- **Scenarios:** ALL

- **Actions by scenario:**

- WITHIN_SAME_MUNICIPALITY: Updated at municipal office during tenkyo todoke
- BETWEEN_MUNICIPALITIES: Updated at new municipal office during tennyu todoke
- LEAVING_JAPAN (permanent): Surrender card at airport immigration on departure day. Officer punches a hole in it. KEEP THE PUNCHED CARD — needed for pension lump-sum withdrawal application.
- LEAVING_JAPAN (temporary with re-entry permit): Keep your card. Show it at departure and re-entry.

7. Re-Entry Permit (再入国許可)

- **Scenarios:** LEAVING_JAPAN (temporary)

- **Types:**

- **Special Re-Entry Permit (みなし再入国許可):** Automatic if returning within 1 year AND your visa has not expired. No application needed — just check the box on the embarkation card at the airport. Free.
- **Regular Re-Entry Permit:** Required if staying abroad longer than 1 year (up to the visa expiration or max 5 years). Apply at Immigration Bureau BEFORE departure. Fee: 3,000 yen (single) or 6,000 yen (multiple).

- **Critical for Permanent Residents:** If you leave WITHOUT a re-entry permit, your Permanent Residency is LOST and cannot be easily recovered. For a PR holder leaving for "a couple of years," you MUST get a Regular Re-Entry Permit (up to 5 years for PR holders).

- **Where to apply:** Regional Immigration Bureau

- **Documents:** Passport, Residence Card, application form, photo, fee (revenue stamp)
-

8. My Number Card (マイナンバーカード)

- **Scenarios:** ALL
 - **Actions by scenario:**
 - WITHIN_SAME_MUNICIPALITY / BETWEEN_MUNICIPALITIES: Address updated at municipal office. Card continues to function.
 - LEAVING_JAPAN: Return or deregister at municipal office before departure. If returning with re-entry permit within stated period, you may be able to keep your My Number for re-registration upon return.
-

9. Resident Tax (住民税) Settlement

- **Scenarios:** LEAVING_JAPAN
 - **Key rule:** Resident tax is based on income from the PREVIOUS year, billed June/July.
 - **If leaving before June:** You will not receive the bill in Japan. Appoint a tax representative (納税管理人 / nouzei kanrinin) to receive and pay on your behalf.
 - **If leaving July-December:** Settle the full year's resident tax before departure if possible.
 - **Tax representative:** Can be any Japanese resident (friend, colleague, accountant). Submit appointment form to local tax office BEFORE leaving.
 - **Exit tax:** If you have assets exceeding 100 million yen and leave without a re-entry permit, exit tax may apply.
-

10. Final Income Tax Return (確定申告)

- **Scenarios:** LEAVING_JAPAN
- **If employed:** Employer typically handles year-end adjustment for mid-year departure.

- **If self-employed or freelance:** File a final tax return covering January 1 to departure date. Can be done by a tax representative after departure.
 - **Deadline:** Before departure, or via tax representative after departure.
-

11. Mail Forwarding (郵便転送)

- **Scenarios:** WITHIN_SAME_MUNICIPALITY, BETWEEN_MUNICIPALITIES
 - **Where:** Any post office or online via Japan Post e-tenkyo service
 - **Duration:** Free forwarding for 1 year
 - **Activation:** 3-7 working days after submission
 - **Documents (in person):** ID showing former address
 - **Notes:** Does NOT forward mail internationally. For LEAVING_JAPAN, use a third-party mail forwarding service or ask a trusted person to handle mail.
-

12. Utilities (Electricity / Gas / Water)

- **Scenarios:** ALL
 - **Actions:**
 - **Old address:** Contact providers to stop service on move-out date
 - **New address (if moving within Japan):**
 - **Electricity:** Can often activate remotely by switching breaker. Register with provider.
 - **Gas:** REQUIRES in-person visit from technician. Book 2+ weeks in advance. Must be home for valve activation.
 - **Water:** Apply online or by phone through local water bureau.
 - **LEAVING_JAPAN:** Cancel all utility contracts. Settle final bills. Some providers require notice 1-2 weeks ahead.
-

13. Internet Service

- **Scenarios:** ALL
- **Deadline:** Cancel with 1 month notice (typical). Some contracts have early termination fees.
- **For moves within Japan:** Check if provider operates in new area. May need new contract.

14. Mobile Phone Contract

- **Scenarios:** ALL
 - **For moves within Japan:** Update address with carrier (online or in-store).
 - **LEAVING_JAPAN:** Cancel contract. Must visit store in person for most carriers (docomo, au, SoftBank). Early termination fees may apply. Do this 2-3 weeks before departure.
-

15. Bank Accounts

- **Scenarios:** ALL
 - **For moves within Japan:** Update registered address at bank (online, app, or branch visit).
 - **LEAVING_JAPAN (permanent):** Close accounts before departure. Transfer funds internationally first. Some banks allow non-resident accounts (check with your bank).
 - **LEAVING_JAPAN (temporary with re-entry):** You can keep accounts open. Update the bank about your temporary departure. Some banks may restrict non-resident access. Keep at least one account open for pension refund receipt, tax payments, etc.
-

16. Driver's License (運転免許証)

- **Scenarios:** WITHIN_SAME_MUNICIPALITY, BETWEEN_MUNICIPALITIES
 - **Where:** Police station or Driver's License Center
 - **When:** After your Residence Card reflects new address
 - **Documents:** Residence Certificate (住民票) issued within 6 months, current license
 - **Notes:** Not needed if leaving Japan permanently.
-

17. Employer / School Notification

- **Scenarios:** ALL
 - **Deadline:** Inform promptly upon deciding to move
 - **Notes:** Employer may need to update social insurance, commuter pass, etc. If changing employer's address in the immigration system, report to Immigration Bureau within 14 days.
-

18. Children's School Transfer

- **Scenarios:** BETWEEN_MUNICIPALITIES, LEAVING_JAPAN
 - **Actions:**
 - Notify current school - Obtain transfer documents (在学証明書, 教科書給与証明書)
 - Register at new school through new municipal office education board
 - **Deadline:** Before the move if possible
-

19. Pet Registration Transfer

- **Scenarios:** ALL (if you have pets)
 - **Dogs:** Transfer dog registration (犬の登録変更届) at new municipal office within 30 days
 - **Leaving Japan with pets:** Obtain export health certificate from Animal Quarantine Service. Check destination country's import requirements (rabies vaccination, microchip, quarantine). Apply at least 2-3 months before departure.
-

20. Vehicle Registration (if applicable)

- **Scenarios:** BETWEEN_MUNICIPALITIES
- **Where:** Land Transport Office (陸運局)
- **Deadline:** Within 15 days of address change
- **Documents:** Updated Residence Certificate, current vehicle registration, proof of parking (車庫証明) at new address
- **Notes:** License plates change if moving to a different registration district.

21. Insurance (Private / Life / Car)

- **Scenarios:** ALL
 - **Actions:** Update address with all private insurance providers. If leaving Japan, review policy terms — some policies become void for non-residents.
-

22. Subscriptions and Memberships

- **Scenarios:** ALL
 - **Actions:** Update address for: credit cards, Amazon, online shopping accounts, gym memberships, library cards, loyalty programs, etc.
 - **LEAVING_JAPAN:** Cancel subscriptions that won't be used abroad.
-

TIMELINE TEMPLATE

Moving Within Japan (WITHIN_SAME_MUNICIPALITY or BETWEEN_MUNICIPALITIES)

| When | Tasks | |-----|-----| | 1 month before | Notify landlord (check lease notice period). Contact utility/internet providers. Start mail forwarding registration. | | 2 weeks before | File Moving-Out Notification (転出届) if moving between municipalities. | | Moving day | Key handover. Final meter readings. | | Within 14 days after | File Moving-In (転入届) or Change of Address (転居届). Update NHI. Update Residence Card. Update My Number Card. | | Within 1 month after | Update bank accounts. Update driver's license. Transfer pet registration. Update vehicle registration (if applicable). Update employer/school. |

Leaving Japan

| When | Tasks | |-----|-----| | 3 months before | Research procedures. Notify employer. Begin selling/shipping belongings. Apply for Re-Entry Permit if planning to return (Immigration Bureau). | | 2 months before | Notify landlord. Begin

closing/updating bank accounts. Arrange pet export if applicable. | | 6 weeks before | Cancel internet (1-month notice typical). | | 1 month before | Cancel mobile phone (in-store visit). Arrange tax representative. Cancel private insurance or update. | | 2-3 weeks before | Close/update bank accounts. Cancel subscriptions. | | 2 weeks before | File Moving-Out Notification (転出届) at city hall. Cancel NHI. Return My Number Card. Settle resident tax. Cancel utilities (schedule stop date). Set up mail handling. | | Departure day | Return Residence Card at airport immigration (KEEP the punched card). | | Within 2 years after | Apply for pension lump-sum withdrawal from home country (if eligible and desired). |

SPECIAL CASE: PERMANENT RESIDENT LEAVING TEMPORARILY

This is the demo scenario. Key nuances:

- **Re-Entry Permit is CRITICAL.** Without it, PR status is permanently lost. For absences longer than 1 year, apply for Regular Re-Entry Permit at Immigration Bureau before departure (valid up to 5 years for PR holders). For absences under 1 year, Special Re-Entry Permit (automatic at airport) is sufficient.
- **Pension decision:** Can either (a) keep paying voluntarily to build pension record, or (b) stop and claim lump-sum withdrawal. For PR holders planning to return, keeping the pension record is often better long-term, especially if close to the 10-year minimum for receiving pension benefits.
- **NHI:** Must cancel when filing tenshutsu todoke. Will re-enroll upon return and re-registration.
- **Bank accounts:** Keep at least one open for any remaining tax payments, pension matters, or receiving refunds. Notify the bank of temporary departure.
- **Resident tax:** Still owed for the current fiscal year. Appoint a tax representative if bills will arrive after departure.
- **Residence Card:** Keep it (do NOT surrender at airport if you have a re-entry permit).
- **My Number:** Can potentially retain for re-registration upon return.
- **Apartment/housing:** If breaking lease, follow normal lease termination. If keeping the apartment, notify landlord of temporary absence.

DATA SOURCES AND DISCLAIMERS

- Procedures verified against official sources: Ministry of Internal Affairs (soumu.go.jp), Immigration Services Agency (moj.go.jp), Japan Pension Service, Japan Post, and multiple municipal government websites.
- Deadlines and fine amounts are current as of 2026 but may change.
- Specific requirements can vary slightly by municipality. Users should confirm details with their local municipal office.
- This reference covers common cases for foreign residents. Edge cases (diplomatic status, special permanent residents, stateless persons) may differ.